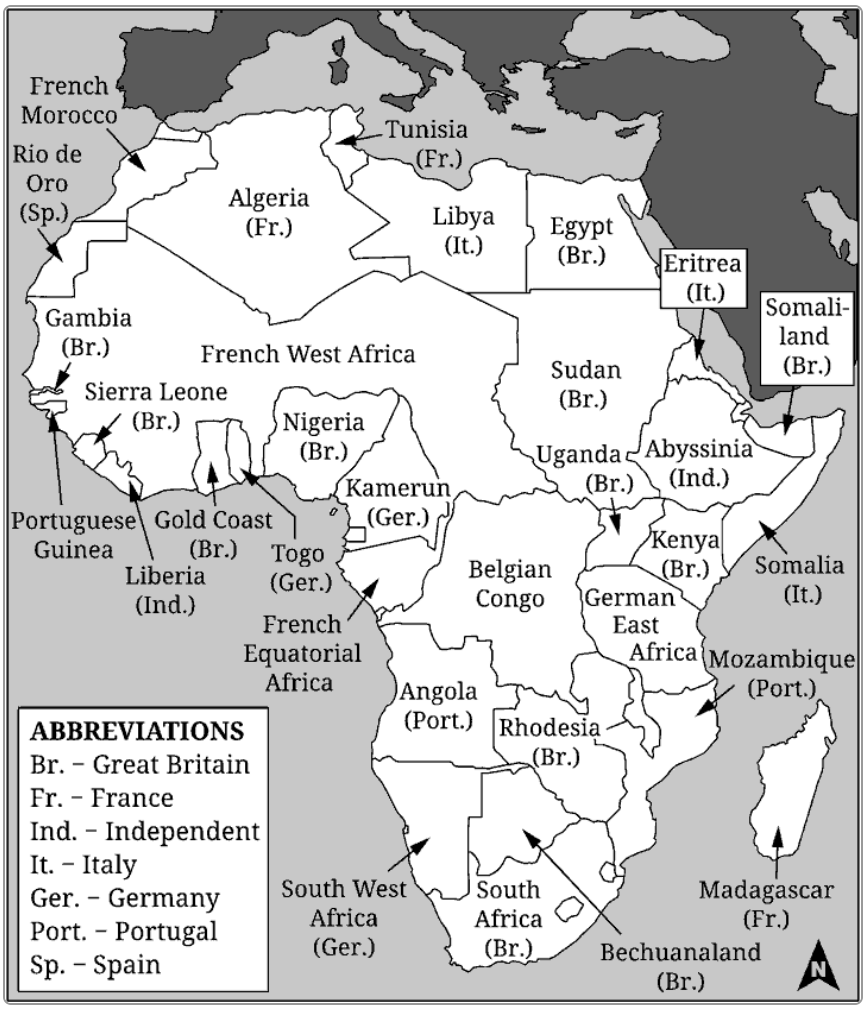
Lines on the Map

AP Human Geography · Unit 4 · Two stimuli (like Question 3) · 7 points · Teacher key · GeoArcade FRQ Tutor

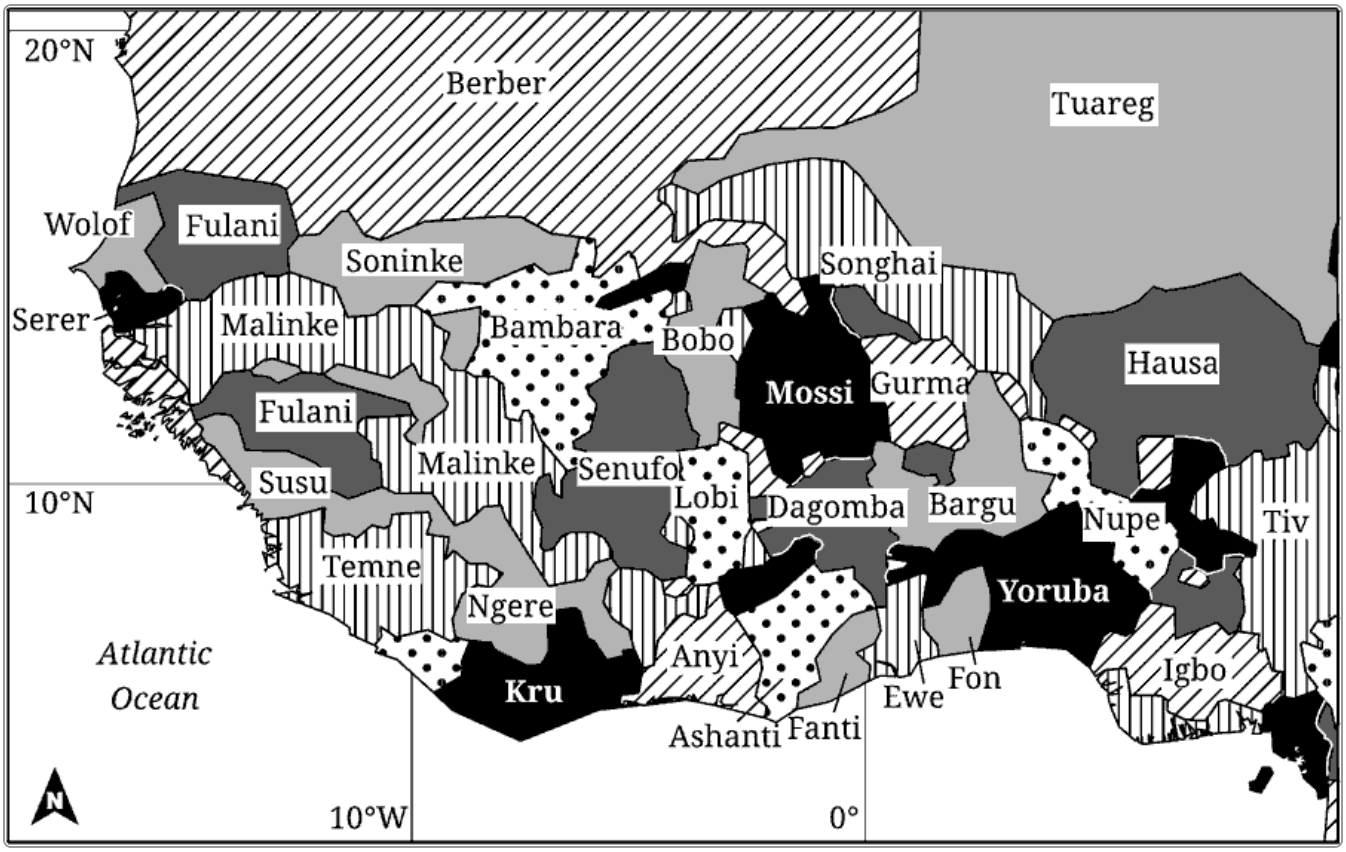
In the 1880s, European powers began invading and occupying the interior areas of Africa, which were inhabited by a variety of diverse culture groups. By 1900, European countries had claimed nearly 90 percent of African territory and redrawn the political boundaries of Africa, many of which remain today.

Map 1: Africa, Political Boundaries in 1890



Source: Library of Congress. Some labels (French Morocco, Italian Libya) date from about 1912, not 1890.

Map 2: Larger Culture Groups in West Africa



Note: Map 2 shows where West Africa's larger culture groups live. It does not show any political borders.

Remember the class directions: label each part, and write every Describe and Explain part as T1- (your answer in general words) → E2- (the specific proof) → A3- (why it matters).

A. Describe the type of political boundaries shown in Map 1. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names the type: superimposed or geometric (or physical, along rivers)
- Gives proof: who drew it, what it ignored, or a Map 1 border

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Map 1 shows mostly superimposed boundaries, and many of them are geometric.
E2- European powers like Britain and France drew them as long straight lines, such as the borders that cross the Sahara between Algeria, Libya, Egypt, and Sudan.
A3- Because outsiders drew these lines, they ignored the culture groups who already lived there.

Common mistake: "The boundaries on Map 1 are the borders between African countries." That says what the lines are, not their TYPE. Name the type (superimposed or geometric) and point to proof on Map 1.

Why the model works: It names the type, points to real borders on Map 1, and says why it matters.

B. Describe ONE way that the European colonial boundaries shown in Map 1 differ from the African cultural boundaries shown in Map 2. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Colonial side: drawn by Europeans, often straight, ignoring or splitting groups
- Cultural side: irregular edges that follow where groups live

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The colonial boundaries on Map 1 are often straight lines that ignore culture groups, while the cultural boundaries on Map 2 are irregular and follow where each group lives.
E2- For example, the Hausa homeland on Map 2 was split between British Nigeria and French West Africa, and the Ewe between the Gold Coast and German Togo.
A3- This shows that Europeans drew borders to divide land among themselves, not to match African nations.

Common mistake: "Map 1 shows colonies and Map 2 shows culture groups." That says what each map shows, not how the boundaries differ (like who drew them, or their shape).

Why the model works: It describes both sides, proves it with groups the borders split, and says what that shows.

C. Explain ONE political outcome for present-day Africans as a result of the European colonial boundaries. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a political outcome (civil war, separatism, border disputes)
- Explains how: groups forced together or split apart

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One political outcome is ethnic conflict and civil war inside African countries.
E2- Britain's Nigeria combined the Hausa-Fulani north, the Yoruba southwest, and the Igbo southeast, and in 1967 the Igbo region tried to break away as Biafra, starting a civil war (1967–70).
A3- Because the borders put peoples with different languages, religions, and histories under one government, competition for power turned violent.

Common mistake: "Colonial boundaries caused a lot of problems in Africa." Too vague. Name a political outcome (like civil war) and explain how the borders caused it.

Why the model works: It names an outcome, proves it with Biafra, and explains how the borders caused it.

D. Describe ONE way that European colonization of Africa reflected the concept of ethnocentrism. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Shows the attitude: Europeans saw their culture as superior
- Gives a specific example (Berlin Conference, civilizing mission, imposed religion or language)

MODEL ANSWER

T1- European colonization reflected ethnocentrism because Europeans judged African cultures by their own standards and saw their own culture as superior.
E2- At the Berlin Conference (1884–85), European leaders set the rules for dividing Africa without inviting a single African, and colonizers later pushed Christianity and European languages on Africans as a so-called "civilizing mission."
A3- This shows ethnocentrism because Europeans assumed African kingdoms and cultures didn't count.

Common mistake: "Ethnocentrism is when you think your culture is better than other cultures." A correct definition, but it never connects to Africa. Add an example, like the Berlin Conference.

Why the model works: It shows the attitude, gives specific examples, and explains why that's ethnocentric.

E. Explain ONE way that the political boundaries shown in Map 1 illustrate a European colonial emphasis on resource extraction. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Uses Map 1: colonies drawn to reach coasts, rivers, ports, or resource-rich land
- Explains extraction: moving raw materials out to Europe

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The boundaries on Map 1 show an emphasis on resource extraction because many colonies were drawn to include a coast or a major river for shipping raw materials out.
E2- For example, the huge Belgian Congo reaches the Atlantic through a narrow strip at the mouth of the Congo River, and the Gold Coast and Togo are narrow strips running inland from the shore.
A3- This let colonizers move rubber, gold, and cocoa from the interior to ports and on to Europe, instead of linking African communities to each other.

Common mistake: "Europeans wanted Africa's resources, like gold and rubber." True, but it never uses Map 1's boundaries. Point to a border feature, like colonies drawn to include coasts.

Why the model works: It names the border pattern, points to Map 1, and explains how it moved raw materials to Europe.

F. Explain the degree to which colonization affected the languages spoken in present-day Africa. EXPLAIN THE DEGREE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- States a degree: great, large, moderate, or small
- Proves it: official European languages, or African languages still spoken

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Colonization affected the languages spoken in present-day Africa to a large degree, but not completely.
E2- European languages are still official in many countries, like French in Senegal, English in Nigeria and Ghana, and Portuguese in Angola, where they are used in government, schools, and business.
A3- They lasted partly because many governments saw them as not favoring any one ethnic group, but the effect isn't total: most Africans still speak African languages like Hausa, Swahili, or Amharic at home.

Common mistake: "Colonization affected African languages because Europeans brought their languages to Africa." There's no degree! Say HOW MUCH first (great, moderate, or small), then prove it.

Why the model works: It states a degree, proves it with specific countries, and explains why the effect isn't total.

G. Explain a possible limitation of using Map 2 to understand the geography of religion in present-day Africa. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- States the limit: culture groups, not religions (or only West Africa)
- Explains why: one group can hold several faiths, or the map misses places or change

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One limitation is that Map 2 shows culture groups, not religions, and one culture group can include people of several faiths.
E2- For example, the Yoruba include many Muslims, many Christians, and followers of traditional Yoruba religion, but Map 2 shades the whole Yoruba area the same way.
A3- Because Islam and Christianity spread across culture-group lines through trade and missionaries, using Map 2 to guess religion would give a false picture of where each faith is practiced today.

Common mistake: "Map 2 doesn't show religion." That's the start, but Explain needs the why: one culture group, like the Yoruba, can include several religions.

Why the model works: It names the limitation, proves it with the Yoruba, and explains how Map 2 alone would mislead.
